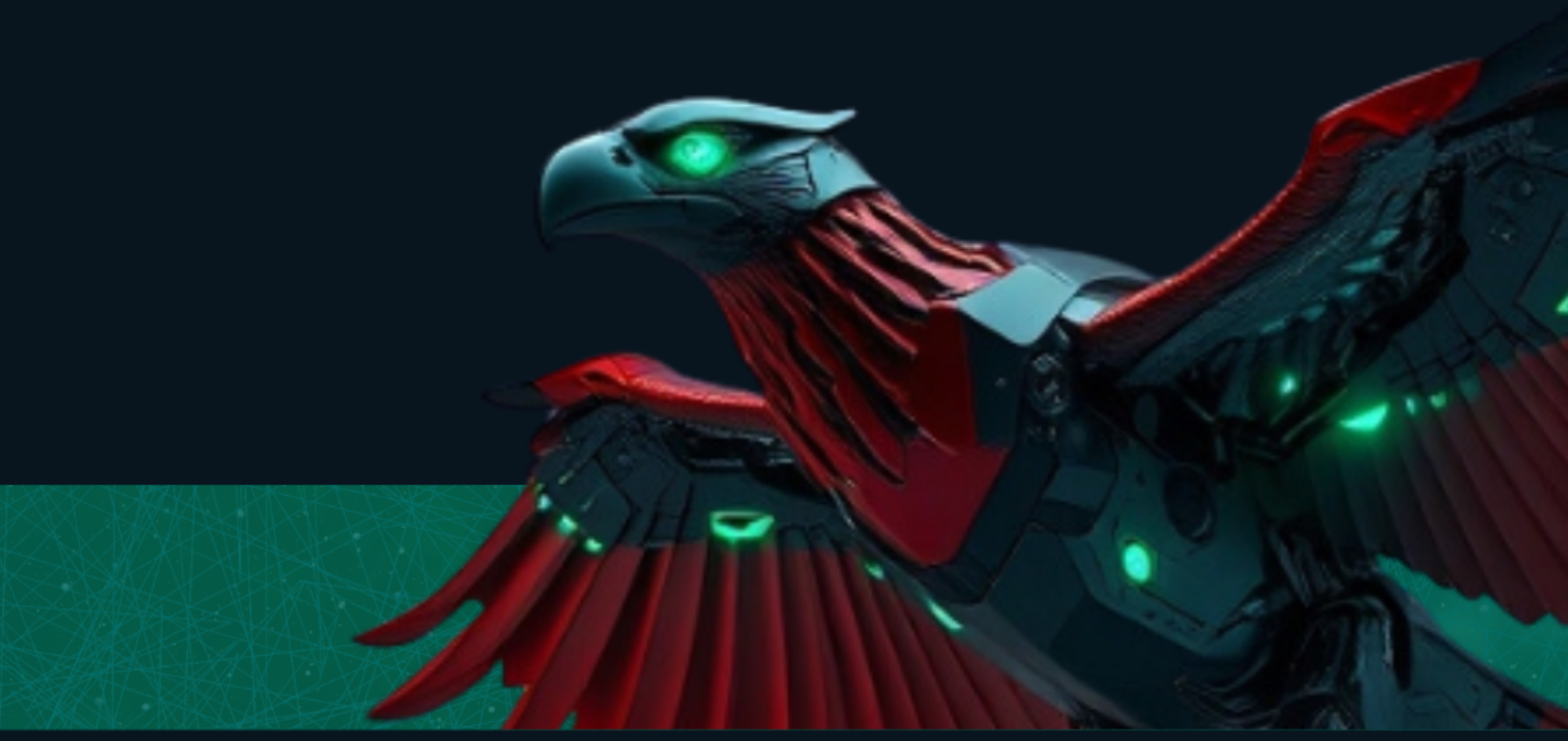
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INTEL REPORT



Report Details

Title	Threat Hunt | Ethereal Panda
Sub Title	A highly sophisticated, state-sponsored advanced persistent threat group originating from China.
Status	Closed
Type	Alert
Severity	—
Source	Multiple Sources
Created At	Jun 16, 2026, 08:40 PM

Threat Hunt | Ethereal Panda

A highly sophisticated, state-sponsored advanced persistent threat group originating from China.

Type: ALERT • Source: Multiple Sources • Created At: Jun 16, 2026, 08:40 PM

Analysis Summary

On June 16th, 2026 at 8:00 PM, Cythority's vSOC conducted a threat hunt focused on Ethereal Panda covering activity within the past 30 days.

Ethereal Panda is a highly sophisticated, state-sponsored advanced persistent threat group originating from China. Active since at least mid-2021, the group's primary objective is cyber espionage and long-term intelligence gathering rather than immediate sabotage or financial gain. Geopolitically, their operations heavily target organizations in Taiwan, specifically focusing on government agencies, academic institutions, telecommunications, and critical manufacturing - though their footprint has expanded globally into North America, Southeast Asia, and Africa.

What distinguishes Ethereal Panda from many other threat actors is their deliberate choice to operate with minimal custom malware, choosing instead to execute quiet, "hands-on-keyboard" campaigns designed to maintain low-profile access for as long as possible. Rather than attempting to compromise internal user workstations directly via phishing, they aggressively focus on edge infrastructure. They routinely scan for and exploit known vulnerabilities in public-facing applications, enterprise network devices (like VPN gateways and firewalls), and servers running unpatched Java, web, or SQL services.

To achieve their goals without tripping endpoint detection alerts, the group relies heavily on "Living-off-the-Land" techniques - abusing legitimate, built-in operating system utilities and administrative binaries like PowerShell, certutil, and Windows Terminal. Once inside a network, they typically deploy compact web shells for initial entry, elevate their local privileges using public open-source exploits, and dump credential hashes from LSASS memory using tools like Mimikatz. For long-term persistence and

lateral movement, they routinely modify the Windows registry to bypass Network Level Authentication (NLA), manipulate accessibility features (like Sticky Keys) to spawn high-privilege command prompts from the login screen, and install legitimate third-party software like SoftEther VPN to tunnel encrypted communication right out of the network disguised as normal web traffic.

During this hunt, a total of [19] Indicators of Compromise (IOCs) were identified, including domains, URLs, IP addresses, email addresses, filenames, and file hash values. These indicators were aggregated from CrowdStrike, internal telemetry, and additional intelligence sources referenced in this report. All identified IOCs were enriched using OSINT and threat intelligence platforms to validate their reputation. Analysis confirmed that the indicators are associated with malicious activity.

A CQL Advanced Event Search was conducted across the environment to identify any evidence of activity related to these indicators. No matches or suspicious activity were observed, confirming no current or historical presence within the environment. As a preventative measure, the validated malicious IOCs have been added to the IOC Management Block List to mitigate potential future exposure. This proactive control strengthens the security posture and reduces the attack surface.

Based on the investigation and analysis performed, no impact to the environment has been identified and no further action is required at this time.

Targeted Industries:

Government, Technology, Academic, Telecommunications, Transportation, Media, Healthcare, Aerospace

Targeted Countries:

China, Malaysia, Rwanda, Nigeria, Taiwan, United States, Kenya, Thailand, Japan, India, Cambodia, South Korea

Community Identifiers:

Flax Typhoon, RedJuliett, Storm-0919

Affected Product

- Networking and Edge Routing Infrastructure
- Network-Attached Storage (NAS) & Smart Devices (IoT)
- Enterprise Security and Secure Remote Access (VPNs)
- Enterprise Software, Servers, and Databases

Impact

- Exploitation of Public-Facing Application (T1190)
- Execution (TA0002)Command and Scripting Interpreter (T1059)
- Persistence (TA0003)
- Privilege Escalation (TA0004)
- Web Shell (T1505.003)
- Accessibility Features (T1546.008)
- Exploitation for Privilege Escalation (T1068)
- Defense Evasion (TA0005)
- Masquerading (T1036)
- Modify Authentication Process (T1556)
- Credential Access (TA0006)
- OS Credential Dumping (T1003)
- Lateral Movement (TA0008)
- Remote Desktop Protocol (T1021.001)
- Network Service Discovery (T1046)
- Command and Control (TA0011)
- Protocol Tunneling (T1572)

Indicators of Compromise (IOCs)

MD5 Hashes

- 73ca0329daa6717442ac87fe94925243
- A973c0ab904c1b74655a906b99b76850
- 9b43f16dd041a9d880702b56511226d0
- 8c993f55001983e50ad019df522b48f0
- 16a36f91346b3c5f4667bc8baf84282a

SHA256 Hashes

- b1552703ff0035f197c22cdb3a514bb6aa45ec98de3ef5409faab0978f18c35e
- 480adaf00b6903321c8fceef1a90ff86972fa2450d6601fe3a4c9f5ac173544e
- C1d68fb62f45fbd2eb5343d3bf1031df2a73dbbf43d541452b0a6e0119b62806
- 39de0389d3186234e544b449e20e48bd9043995ebf54f8c6b33ef3a4791b6537
- 0fac58c98c3582133bec8a776ef18608fb4abaa96f0f53d26f917c5b828cdaf2

IP

- 45[.]229[.]248[.]3
- 183[.]83[.]146[.]87
- 102[.]141[.]73[.]59
- 38[.]60[.]253[.]35

DOMAIN

- imagefiles-backup[.]oss-ap-southeast-7[.]aliyuncs[.]com
- trendupdate.net
- javaup[.]accesscam[.]org
- data[.]microsofttw[.]com
- microsofttw[.]com

Remediation

- Audit and Patch Edge Devices
- Decommission End-of-Life (EOL) Hardware
- Disable Unnecessary Management Interfaces

- Implement PowerShell Constrained Language Mode
- Enforce Attack Surface Reduction (ASR) Rules
- Monitor and Validate Built-in Utilities
- Enforce Network Level Authentication (NLA)
- Credential Dumping Mitigation
- Strict Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA)
- Inspect Encrypted Outbound Traffic
- Hunt for Web Shells
- Review RDP and Service Creation Logs